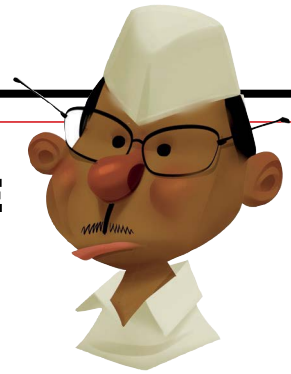
VIRAL TROUBLE



A viral video of Maharashtra minister **Narhari Zirwal** with a trans woman in a bedroom at his quarters has led to speculation that the NCP leader may be shown the door. He's denied any wrongdoing, and speculation is also rife that it's an "inside job", considering the tug of war within the party for ministerial berths. Already, a cabinet seat from the NCP quota is lying vacant after sports minister Manikrao Kokate quit. Will Zirwal be next?



BLADE RUNNERS

Madhya Pradesh's rulers were past masters at swordery; and the tradition survives among present-day politicians. Chief Minister **Mohan Yadav** has been known to display his sword-wielding skills at traditional events like Rang Panchami, a handy tool for showmanship but also perhaps a signal of his political might. Now, other leaders, deputy CM Jagdish Devda among them, are picking up the blade, staging choreographed moves. The latest is ex-minister and Sanchi MLA, Dr Prabhuram Chaudhary, who was seen swinging a cutlass with surprising ease at a recent Ramnavami event. The soft-spoken doctor hardly seemed the type for such hardline posturing, but with a cabinet expansion imminent, a little swashbucklery can't hurt.

FLYING RIPOSTE



The inauguration of the Noida International Airport in Uttar Pradesh doubled as a political stage. Prime Minister Narendra Modi levelled a familiar charge, accusing the former Samajwadi Party (SP) government of turning Noida into an "ATM for loot", and pitching the current BJP regime as the agent of development. SP chief **Akhilesh Yadav** avoided a direct riposte, but posted a measured message with the PM's photo: "They have come to our state as guests, and we will treat them as guests and send them off with respect," adding, pointedly, that "the words of those who are leaving are not taken to heart." The subtext was sharp: the BJP's tenure in UP is temporary. With 2027 in sight, even an airport opening feels like a poll campaign duel.

Kaushik Deka with Prasad Nichenametla, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Rahul Noronha and Avaneesh Mishra

ECO WATCH

THE GREAT INDIAN BUSTARD
RARE WILD CHICK IN KUTCH

By **Jumana Shah**

A rare conservation breakthrough has emerged from Gujarat's grasslands in Kutch, where a critically endangered Great Indian Bustard chick has hatched in the wild for the first time in over a decade.

The chick hatched on March 26 in the Abdasa area of Kutch, a landscape known to support a small but stable population of the species till 2011. The birth is the result of a carefully coordinated conservation intervention involving the Gujarat and Rajasthan forest departments, the Union environment ministry, and the Wildlife Institute of India. The effort used a 'jumpstart' approach, in which an egg collected from a breeding programme in Rajasthan's Jaisalmer was transported roughly 770 km to Kutch by road over 19 hours in a handheld portable incubator and was replaced in the nest on March 22. The egg was then placed in the wild and incubated by a local female bustard, which effectively acted as a foster mother.

"We are keeping our fingers crossed for the survival of the chick," Union environment minister Bhupender Yadav wrote on his social media post.

Officials say the chick is now being raised in its natural habitat, a critical factor for its long-term survival, as it allows the bird to learn essential behaviours such as foraging and predator avoidance. Conservationists view this as a step forward from captive breeding, which has had limited success in restoring viable wild populations. The GIB captive breeding project was launched in 2016, when the



bird's overall population in the country had dropped to 140-150 (90 per cent of them in Rajasthan). The 2025 census reports that around 130 birds remain in the wild in Rajasthan, and around four in Gujarat.

Two breeding centres started in Jaisalmer—the Sam (Sudasari) Conservation Breeding Centre and the Ramdevra breeding facility—now have 73 birds, with five new chicks hatched this season.